1.2 Slavery and Racism

Enslaved people in the South thought running away from their plantations would change their lives for the better. But would freedom in the North live up to its promise?

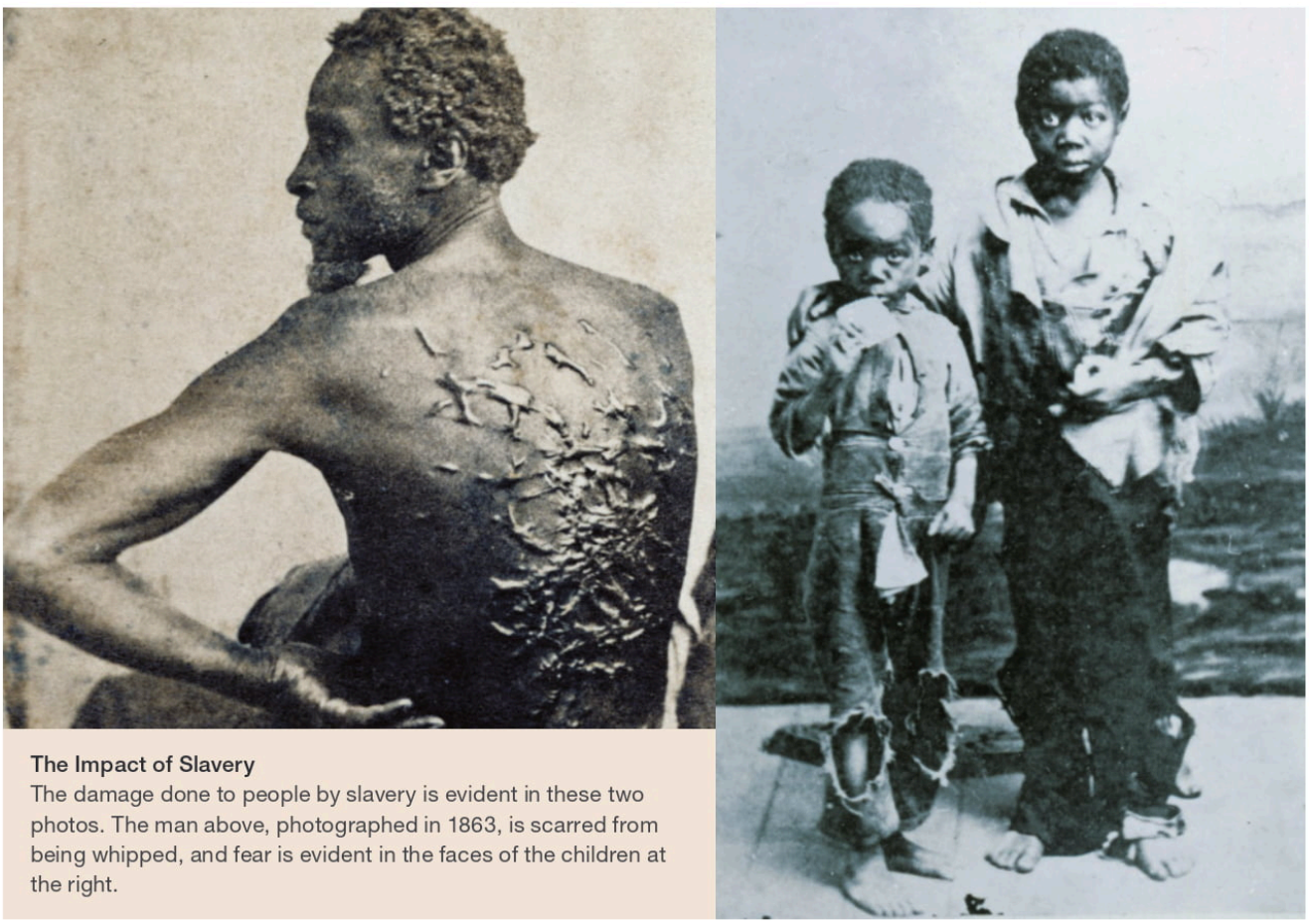
MAIN IDEA Racism and slavery were defining forces in the lives of African Americans in both the South and the North.

AFRICAN AMERICANS IN THE SOUTH

While some Americans began to harbor misgivings over slavery, the slave trade continued to thrive in the South. Enslaved people from Africa were no longer imported. But since the children of enslaved people in the United States also became slaves, the slave population grew steadily in the South. By 1860, there were nearly four million enslaved African Americans in the region.

Racism, or the belief that one race is superior to others, was the foundation upon which slavery was built. Many slave owners justified slavery by claiming that African Americans were better off under the care of plantation owners than they would be by caring for themselves. But, as you know, many slaves endured lives of unspeakable cruelty. Laws such as the Fugitive Slave Acts made sure their lives could never improve by sharply curbing their freedom and economic opportunities.

Racist attitudes also affected the lives of the more than 250,000 free African Americans in the South. Local laws prevented them from traveling or assembling in large groups. Free African Americans were also discouraged from



The Impact of Slavery
The damage done to people by slavery is evident in these two photos. The man above, photographed in 1863, is scarred from being whipped, and fear is evident in the faces of the children at the right.

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A writer named **Harriet Beecher Stowe** channeled her anger over slavery into a novel called *Uncle Tom's Cabin.* This 1852 painting called *An American Slave Market,* by an artist known only as Taylor, depicts a scene in the novel in which a slave trader purchases a child.

Published in 1852, *Uncle Tom's Cabin* sold 300,000 copies in that year alone and was also turned into popular plays. It dramatically changed the national debate over slavery and racism.

organizing churches, schools, and fraternal orders, or social organizations, like the Masons.

Slavery was central to the economy and culture of the agrarian South. Concerned about the health of the South's economy, southern leaders not only fought for slavery but they also battled against tariffs. They argued that high tariffs favored the industrial North and hurt the South by forcing plantation owners to pay higher prices for manufactured goods.

Some wealthy plantation owners even tried to convince the U.S. government to acquire Cuba from Spain as a slave state. Their proposal was presented in the 1854 Ostend Manifesto and included the provision that the island be taken by force if necessary. The manifesto fell through, but it became a rallying cry for northern abolitionists, who saw the move as an attempt to extend slavery.

AFRICAN AMERICANS IN THE NORTH

Though some enslaved people dreamed of escaping to the North, those who succeeded found themselves facing many of the challenges they thought they had left behind. Many northerners held the same racist beliefs that were common among southerners. They did not want to live near, work with, or have their children go to school with African Americans. They cared little about ending slavery and looked upon free African Americans with scorn. Even as they worked to try to end the institution of slavery, some abolitionists held racist attitudes toward African Americans.

Discrimination took several forms. Some states passed laws restricting the rights of African Americans to vote, own property, and move about freely. **Segregation**, or the separation of people based on race, was common in northern cities, and African Americans often were forbidden from entering white churches, schools, and many other buildings. They were often blocked from employment for skilled jobs. Free African Americans even feared for their lives. Daily threats included attacks by white mobs and the possibility of being captured and sent back to a life of slavery.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the relationship between racism and slavery?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What forms of discrimination did African Americans face in the North?
3. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How were the situations of free African Americans in the North and the South similar?

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